Novella – Product Feature Specification

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Overview

Novella is a Mac desktop app that turns a story into a comic book, chunk by chunk, using AI models the user picks at install time and can swap per scene. This spec is extracted from the handwritten sketch "New UX Flows for Novella", which holds two flows: an Installation Flow and a User Flow.

The sketch covers eight capabilities: local install with model selection, a project menu, three ways to ingest a story, visual story chunking, a mind map, character creation with images, storyline visualisation by chunk, and per-chunk review with model-based regeneration. A ninth, publication of the finished comic, was added in review. Where the handwriting was ambiguous, the reading used here is marked *(inferred)* and repeated under Open questions.

Installation flow

Installation is a four-step wizard that ends with Novella available as a normal Mac app.

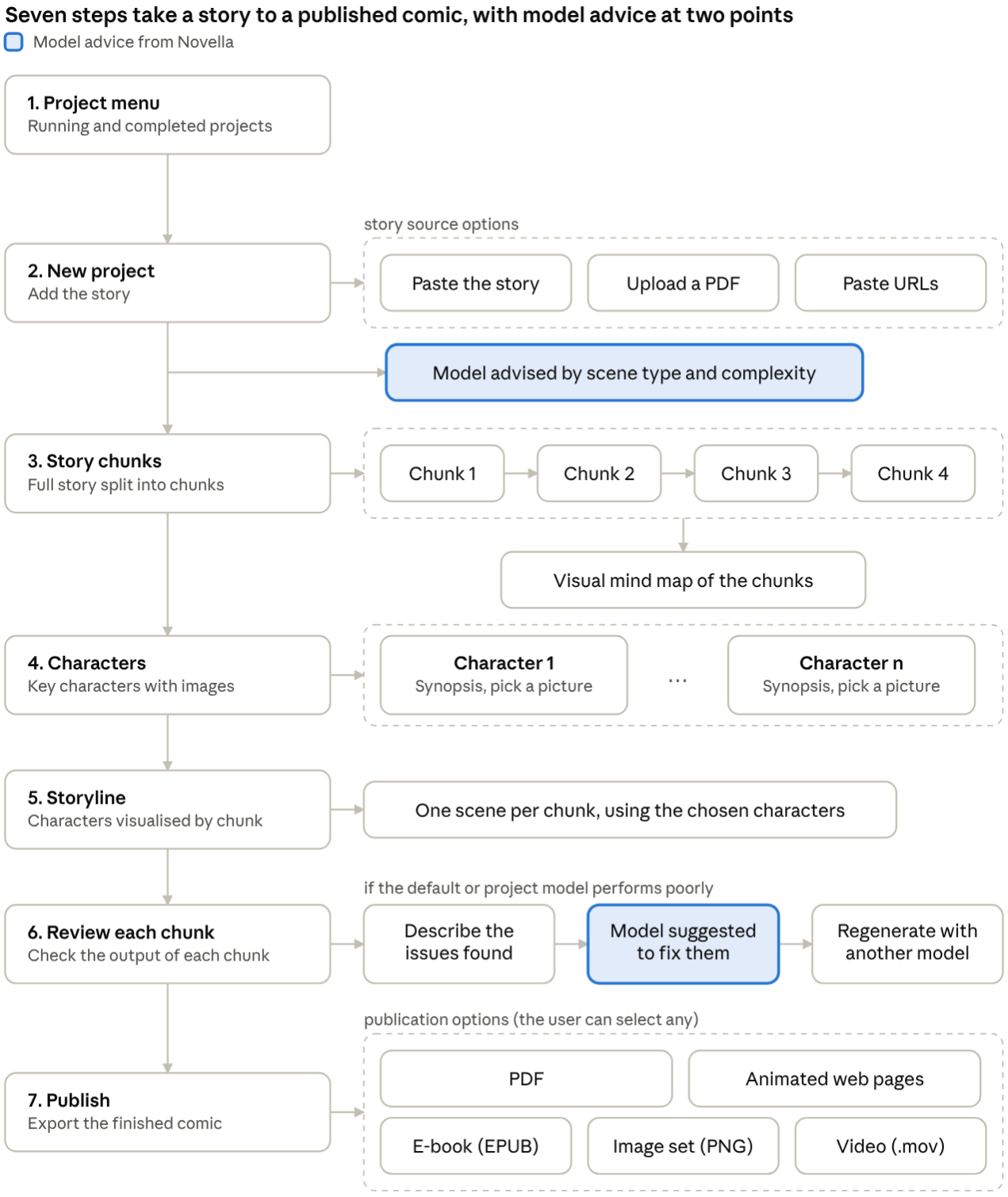
1. Download a DMG file *(inferred from "dry file")*.
2. Start the installer.
3. Select the models to make available for comic book generation, from a catalogue of open-source models to download and from frontier models connected by API key.
4. Select the drive location where Novella projects are stored.

When the wizard finishes, the app appears in the Mac Applications folder.

Two points follow from this order. Model choice happens before first launch, so the installer must list available models and fetch or configure the ones chosen. The storage location is set once at install and applies to all projects.

User flow

A project moves through seven steps from story input to a published comic; the shaded boxes mark where Novella advises on the model.



user flow · 6 steps, 2 model-advice points

Read top to bottom. Step numbers match the Sketch source column in the feature table. The sketch shows three source options for the story but does not say whether they can be combined.

Feature specification

The sketch yields 18 features across installation, project setup, story analysis, characters and generation; review comments add eight: three for publication (F19 to F21), two for models (F22 and F23), two for chunking (F24 and F25) and one for releases (F26). Acceptance criteria are my proposed wording, written so each can be tested.

ID	Feature	What it does	Acceptance criteria	Sketch source
F1	Mac installer	Installs Novella from a DMG through a guided installer	App appears in Applications after the wizard completes	Installation flow, steps 1, 2, 5
F2	Model selection at install	User picks which models are available for comic book generation	Only selected models appear in the app; at least one must be chosen *(inferred)*	Installation flow, step 3
F3	Project storage location	User chooses the drive location where projects are saved	New projects are written under the chosen location	Installation flow, step 4
F4	Project menu	Home screen listing running and completed projects	Each project shows a running or completed state; selecting one opens it	User flow, step 1
F5	New project	Starts a project from the project menu	A new project is created and asks for a story source	User flow, step 2
F6	Paste story	Accepts the story as pasted text	Pasted text becomes the project's full story	User flow, step 2
F7	Upload PDF	Accepts the story as an uploaded PDF	Text is extracted from the PDF and becomes the full story	User flow, step 2

ID	Feature	What it does	Acceptance criteria	Sketch source
F8	Paste URLs	Accepts one or more URLs as the story source	Page content from each URL is fetched and combined into the full story	User flow, step 2
F9	Context-based model recommendation	Recommends a model based on story complexity and scene type (landscape, human figures, drama and similar)	A recommended model is shown before chunking; user can accept or change it	User flow, left margin note
F10	Visual story chunking	Automatically splits the full story into ordered chunks and shows them visually	Chunks 1 to n display in order, each traceable to its part of the full story	User flow, step 3
F11	Visual mind map	Gives the user an editable mind map of the story chunks	Mind map is available from the chunk view, reflects the current chunks, and edits made in it update the chunks	User flow, right-hand note
F12	Key character list	Lists all key characters in the story, each with a synopsis	Every named key character appears with a synopsis; list covers characters 1 to n	User flow, step 4
F13	Character image	Lets the user pick a picture for each character by uploading their own or by generating options and choosing one	Each character can have one image, either uploaded or chosen from generated options, stored with the project	User flow, step 4
F14	Storyline visualisation	Uses the characters to visualise the story as a storyline organised by chunk	Each chunk shows a generated scene featuring the chosen character images	User flow, step 5

ID	Feature	What it does	Acceptance criteria	Sketch source
F15	Per-chunk review	User reviews the generated output of every chunk	Each chunk can be opened and judged before the project is completed	User flow, step 6
F16	Regenerate with a different model	Regenerates a scene with another model when the default or project model performs poorly	User picks any installed model and the chunk is regenerated without affecting other chunks	User flow, step 6
F17	Prompt-driven model advice	Accepts a prompt describing the issues found and recommends which model can solve them	After the prompt is submitted, a recommended model is offered for regeneration	User flow, step 6
F18	Cost vs performance view	For each prompt stage, shows a cost versus performance view of the models suited to the prompt's complexity	Each candidate model shows its relative cost and expected performance for that prompt's complexity, with a recommended model marked (metrics to be defined)	Top of page 1 (cut off), review comment
F19	Publish as PDF	Exports the finished comic as a PDF	A PDF is produced with every chunk's scene in story order	Review comment, step 7
F20	Publish as animated web pages	Exports the comic as self-contained animated web pages viewable in a browser	Pages open in a standard browser and show every chunk's scene, animated, in story order; the export is self-contained and needs no hosting	Review comment, step 7

ID	Feature	What it does	Acceptance criteria	Sketch source
F21	Further export formats	Offers an e-book (EPUB), an image set (PNG) and an animated video (.mov) as extra publication options	Every publication format, including PDF and animated web pages, can be selected by the user and produces a file	Review comment, step 7
F22	API keys for frontier models	Provides an interface to enter and store the API key for frontier models such as Claude or OpenAI	A key can be added, replaced and removed; its models then appear in model selection; keys are stored securely on the Mac and never in project files (suggested: macOS Keychain)	Review comment, installation step 3
F23	Open-source model catalogue	Offers a catalogue of open-source models that can be downloaded at install time	Each model is listed with its name and download size (suggested); chosen models download during install and then appear in model selection	Review comment, installation step 3
F24	Chunk granularity setting	Lets the user specify how finely the story is chunked automatically	The user can set the granularity before chunking runs (for example a target number of chunks or chunk length, suggested); changing it re-chunks the story	Review comment, step 3

ID	Feature	What it does	Acceptance criteria	Sketch source
F25	Edit chunks	Lets the user edit the automatic chunks	The user can change where chunks begin and end (for example merge or split, suggested); the chunk view and mind map reflect the change	Review comment, step 3
F26	DMG generation on upgrade	The open-source package includes tooling that generates a new DMG whenever the software is upgraded	Releasing a new version produces a new installable DMG without manual packaging steps	Review comment, installation flow

Model management

The sketch treats the model as a choice made at three levels, with Novella advising at the last two.

- **Installed set.** The user picks the available models once, during installation (F2), choosing from a catalogue of downloadable open-source models (F23) and adding API keys for frontier models such as Claude or OpenAI (F22).
- **Project model.** Novella recommends a model after input (F9), driven by the complexity of the story and the type of scene to generate, such as landscape, human figures or drama; the user keeps it or changes it. This becomes the project default.
- **Per-chunk override.** If the default or project model performs poorly on a chunk, the user regenerates that scene with another installed model (F16). The user can describe the problem in a prompt, and Novella recommends the model best placed to fix it (F17).

The top of the first sketch page shows a cut-off box labelled "cost of prompt" and "feedback". Review comments clarify the cost half: at each prompt stage Novella shows a cost versus performance view of the models suited to that prompt's complexity (F18), so the user can trade quality against spend. The feedback half is out of scope.

Open-source approach

Releasing Novella as open source means publishing its code under a licence that lets anyone use, change and share it, so the spec gains a licensing and community layer. The table lists the decisions to make, with a suggested starting point for each.

Decision	Suggested starting point	Why it matters
Licence	Apache-2.0 where possible	It is permissive, so others can build on Novella, and it adds a patent grant. Where a dependency's licence prevents it, that part keeps its own licence. A copyleft licence such as GPL-3.0 would require derivatives to stay open.
Repository files	README, LICENSE, CONTRIBUTING, CODE_OF_CONDUCT, SECURITY	These are the files contributors look for first; the README can reuse the installation flow above.
Distribution	Source on GitHub; a new signed DMG on GitHub Releases for each version	Keeps the F1 installer while letting developers build from source; the package includes the tooling that generates each new DMG (F26).
Models	Bring your own models; no weights or API keys in the repository	Each model has its own licence and terms, so the installer (F2) points to them rather than bundling them.
User content	Projects stay on the user's drive (F3); no telemetry by default	Stories and character images belong to the user, which builds trust.
Ownership	The code belongs to you, so you set the licence	Third-party code and models keep their own licences and terms.
Governance	One maintainer to start; issues and pull requests open to all	Simple to run now, and more maintainers can join later.

This is general information, not legal advice; check the licence choice with a lawyer if the project has commercial plans.

Open questions

- [x] ~~"Dry file" is read as DMG. Is a signed, notarised DMG the only distribution route?~~
- [x] ~~"Select the App machine" is read as launching the app. Is that right, or is it a step to choose something else?~~
- [x] ~~Where do models come from: bundled, downloaded at install, or called through a remote API? This decides the install size and the meaning of "cost of prompt".~~
- [x] ~~How is a character picture chosen: uploaded by the user, generated and picked from options, or both?~~
- [x] ~~Is chunking automatic, editable by the user, or both? The sketch only shows chunks being displayed.~~
- [x] ~~Is the mind map read-only, or can users edit chunks from it?~~
- [x] ~~What does the "feedback" half of the cut-off box at the top of page 1 mean? Please share the earlier page if you have it.~~
- [x] ~~Which publication formats ship first: PDF and animated web pages only, or also the suggested e-book, image set and video? Are animated pages self-contained files or hosted?~~
- [x] ~~Open source: which licence, and does the code belong to you or to an employer?~~
- [x] ~~Are animated web pages self-contained files or hosted?~~